TOWN CENTRE NEWS

INQUIRY SPECIAL Nº2 **DECEMBER 1991**

THAMESMEAD TOWN CENTRE PROPOSALS REJECTED BY SECRETARY OF STATE



Chairman Alan Cumming

Chairman Alan Cumming reviews the decision and looks to the future

News this week that the Secretary of State for the Environment has refused planning permission for our Town centre expansion proposals comes as a bitter blow to all those Thamesmead residents who have consistently supported our plans over the last two years or so. I find the decision to reject what was an excellent and exciting scheme very disappointing indeed as Thamesmead is constantly criticised for its lack of amenities. Our proposals were to bring a new level of shopping and leisure to Thamesmead. They had enormous implications for employment - up to 1500 jobs - and for the regeneration, not only of Thamesmead, but of surrounding areas. There is no doubt that the development would have represented a new and exciting chapter in the history of Thamesmead and a catalyst for the area as a whole.

"This is a dreadful decision. Our residents have consistently supported the scheme because the project provided much needed jobs and amenities. We have had a lot of bad press recently because the Town lacks these things. We have been without amenities for our residents ever since Thamesmead began, over twenty years ago"

Sam Robinson,
Vice-Chairman Thamesmead Town and Chairman of the Town Centre Working Party

"The Chamber of Commerce wants to encourage any development within the Borough which will benefit residents and firmly believes in competition"

Ron Wilson,
Chief Executive,
Greenwich Chamber of Commerce

Our Directors and officers have been working on these development plans for over three years. During that time the declared support of Thamesmead residents for the scheme has been a vital factor in their firm commitment to the project. Indeed the residents of the Town have contributed greatly with their opinions and ideas for bringing a new heart and focus to our Town. Now we all face the great disappointment of seeing all that work, commitment and support apparently put aside by this one decision.

The purpose of this Town Centre News special edition is to go some way to explain why we think the decision was reached. The Planning Inspector's main objection to the proposals was the expectation that its retail elements would have a damaging effect on both Woolwich town centre and the existing town centre at Thamesmead. Although there appears to be have been no objection to the leisure and community aspects, the scheme was rejected on those grounds alone. The centre pages illustrate the details of our proposal with brief notes on the Inspector's views on the various aspects of the plan.

"Thamesmead cannot develop in isolation from the Borough of which it is a part. Greenwich Council and Thamesmead Town now need to sit down together to work out proposals which meet the needs of the residents of Thamesmead and Woolwich. Woolwich Town Centre is in urgent need of regeneration while Thamesmead needs a shopping centre geared to local residents"

John Austin-Walker,
Chair of Greenwich Council's Health, Environment and Public Protection Committee

The question you will no doubt be asking now is "So where do we go from here"? Great as our disappointment may be, one thing must be clear. Planning for the successful development of our Town remains a top priority. Already our officers are examining closely the Planning Inspector's report, which runs to 60 pages, to discover what possible options are open to us. Although there are no details of alternative plans at this early stage, I can unhesitatingly reinforce the firm commitment of this Company to continue to work towards the provision of better amenities for the people of Thamesmead.

In working towards our aims, I hope that you will continue to give the immense support and encouragement which has always been so vital for this work. I still firmly believe that Thamesmead desperately needs more amenities for leisure and shopping. Although the achievement of these may seem further away than before we must continue to plan together, Company and Community, for a better future for our Town.

SECRETARY OF STATE AGREES WITH GREENWICH COUNCIL'S VIEW THAT SHOPPING FACILITIES PROPOSED WOULD DAMAGE WOOLWICH TOWN CENTRE

THE SECRETARY OF STATE FOR THE ENVIRONMENT FOR EXPANDING THE TOWN CEN

What the Planning Inspector had to say

- The Savacentre element of the proposals will result in unacceptable damage to the vitality and viability of both Thamesmead Town Centre and Woolwich
- Overall, the retail elements of the proposal fail to provide a realistic and practical District Shopping Centre for Thamesmead

The Inspector supported the Company's case for

- Land use boundaries
- Housing land allocation
- Nature conservation and open space
- Highway considerations
- Proposed offices, leisure and entertainment facilities

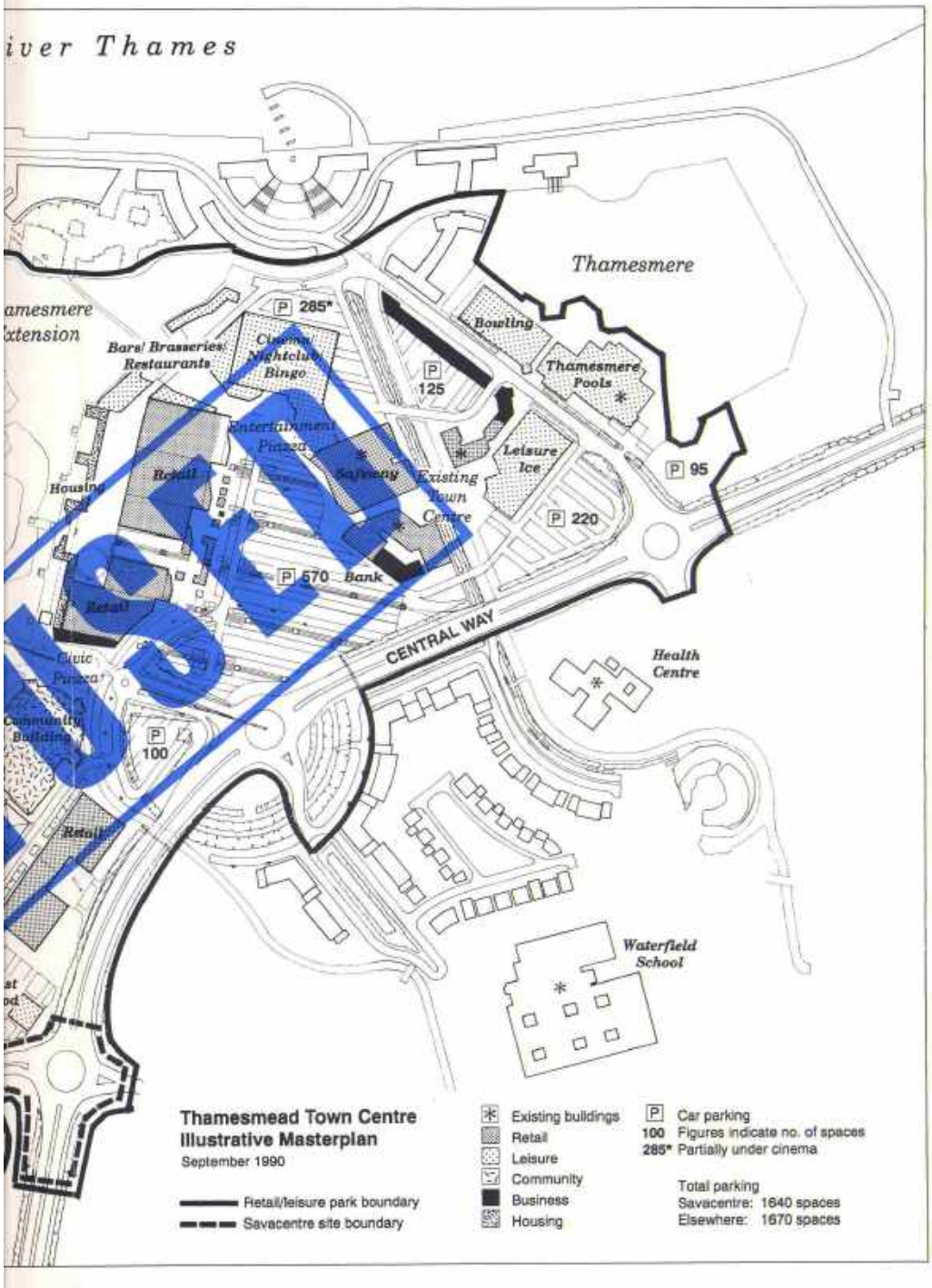
"We have been working on these plans for over three years with the support and encouragement of many Thamesmead residents. This was a very surprising decision and there are a number of inconsistencies in the argument which we will be examining. However there is a new reality created by the decision and we want to see what options remain. Our determination to provide better amenities for Thamesmead remains undiminished and we must continue to plan positively forthe future"

Nick Banks,
Director of Development,
Thamesmead Town



THAMESMEAD TOWN IS NOW EXAM COMMERCIAL OPTIONS AVAILABLE TO TH FOR A VIABLE EXTENSION TO T

MENT HAS REJECTED THE COMPANY'S PROPOSALS CENTRE AFTER A PUBLIC INQUIRY



"The sense of disappointment felt by Company Directors and staff is enormous. It is difficult to express the impact of this decision on all of us after three years' work and commitment. However, we must put this disappointment aside and look to the future. I can reassure this Community that work has already begun to find ways forward to providing the amenities which this Town and Community wants and needs. We look to the Community to once again help and support our efforts"

Philip Glascoe,
Chief Executive,
Thamesmead Town

What Do You Think?

A MESSAGE FROM THE CHAIRMAN

What do you think of the refusal to grant planning permission for the proposed Town Centre?

What are your ideas about the way forward?

Thamesmead Town has received enormous support from the community on this project and this support is still needed if we are to move forward with our intention to provide better facilities for the people of the Town. Drop me a line at the Company office:

Alan Cumming, Chairman
Thamesmead Town
Harrow Manor Way
Thamesmead South
London SE2 9XH

Your views will be taken into account as our work to reassess this project begins.

XAMINING THE LEGAL, PLANNING AND
O THE COMPANY IN PURSUING ITS PLANS
TO THAMESMEAD TOWN CENTRE